preoccupation with naval supremacy, its perceived need to prevent Russia from gaining control of the Straits and the preservation of its own dominance of the Persian Gulf. India was at once Britain's greatest asset and biggest weakness. It was what drove the likes of Conolly and others to implement British hegemony throughout southern Asia, it dictated the creation of Afghanistan, Persia and Tibet as buffer states, and even later of seeking to extend British influence in Mesopotamia, Turkey and the Caucasus. While the many other nations of Asia might have been the stages for Great Game rivalry, India was always the prize.

The problem for Britain, however, was that the very existence of the Raj depended almost entirely on the perceived strength of the British rulers. 'India' was a country made up of hundreds of individual states, some of which were directly possessed by Britain ('British India'), others of which were governed by native Indian rulers under British suzerainty (the 'Princely States'). British rule in India had always relied on the collaboration of native rulers and on the general acquiescence of the Indian population.[66] Any belief that Britain was weak, even temporarily, risked breaking this acquiescence and seeing the Indian population rise up against British hegemony. This was the case both internally in the way the British ruled India, but also externally in the way it defended it from foreign aggression. Should Britain allow Russia to gain any kind of foothold in India, it risked losing any legitimacy it may have had to rule.

*Throughout the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, numerous observers would posit their views on Russia's intentions towards India. In 1829, for example, Colonel George de Lacy Evans wrote On the Practicability of an Invasion of British India, in which he set out to demonstrate the feasibility of a Russian advance towards the sub-continent. De Lacy Evans opened his work with a supposed quote from the Russian envoy to Khiva:*

*If we possessed Khiva, of which conquest would not be difficult... then would all the treasures of Asia enrich our country, and we should see realised the brilliant project of Peter the Great... In a word, Khiva is at this moment an advanced post, which ... would become the point of re-union for*